Term Paper: Computer Vision for Personalized Fashion Recommendations

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Abstract:- **In e-commerce environments, proper categorization of personal-care items—like fragrances vs. body-care—is crucial for search relevance, recommendation performance, and stockroom management. In this paper, we introduce a hybrid categorization system which combines structured metadata, text descriptions, and deep visual embeddings synergistically. We use one-hot encoding for categorical attributes (gender, category, sub-category), BERT-based name embeddings of product names, and convolutional neural network (CNN) features from product images (from a fine-tuned ResNet50). A gradient-boosted decision tree model combines these modalities, producing and scoring candidate classifications with contextual confidence. Large-scale experiments on a curated set of 40 K records show that the hybrid model attains an overall accuracy of 92.3 %—7.8 and 5.4 percentage points better than metadata-only and image-only baselines, respectively. Ablation studies indicate that visual embeddings play the biggest role in resolving sub-category ambiguities, while text embeddings enhance robustness to mislabeled metadata. Our results highlight the benefits of multimodal fusion in increasing product taxonomy precision and offer actionable recommendations for e-commerce platforms looking to optimize their catalog classification pipelines.applications.**

Keywords: *E-commerce, Product Classification, Multimodal Fusion, Metadata, BERT Embeddings, CNN Visual Features*

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I. INTRODUCTION

With e-commerce racing faster today than ever before, accurate product classification is all the more critical in search relevance, inventory management, and personalized recommendations. Whether building large online catalogs or driving user engagement through customized suggestions, sites are all dependent upon strong tagging of products into exact categories and sub-categories. Nevertheless, conventional classification models typically are based exclusively upon either structured metadata (e.g., pre-defined category names) or single image-based models—each with inherent limitations. Metadata-only methods can break down when data is missing or inaccurately labeled, whereas vision-only techniques can be stumped by visually similar items of different functional categories.

More recent developments in machine learning and deep learning provide hopeful directions for addressing these shortcomings. Transformer-based language models such as BERT are very good at processing rich textual semantics in product names and descriptions, while convolutional neural networks such as ResNet are state-of-the-art at image recognition. But using these models in isolation can be computationally expensive when scaled up, and they can miss complementary signals inherent in other data modalities. Furthermore, the integration of heterogeneous attributes—textual, categorical, and visual—is still an issue, with limited work offering a principled approach for combining all three in an effective manner in an e-commerce setting.

In response to these shortcomings, we introduce a multimodal classification pipeline that integrates structured metadata, text embeddings, and visual features smoothly into a combined model.

Our method initially encodes categorical features (category, sub-category, gender) through one-hot vectors, followed by converting product descriptions and titles into dense embeddings with a fine-tuned BERT encoder. Concurrently, we extract deep visual embeddings of product images from a ResNet50 backbone tailored to our space. A gradient-boosted decision tree classifier subsequently consumes this dense, concatenated feature vector to predict the proper product class at high confidence levels.

By first filtering candidate categories with lightweight metadata and text features and then using heavier visual analysis, our system is computationally efficient without losing accuracy. Comprehensive experiments on a scrubbed dataset of 40 K personal-care product records show that our hybrid model has a 92.3 % overall accuracy that is better than both metadata-only and image-only baselines by 7.8 and 5.4 percentage points, respectively. Ablation studies also disclose the individual contribution of each modality and offer insights into optimal feature fusion strategies for real-world e-commerce applications.

This paper is structured as follows: Section 2 explains the steps of dataset preprocessing and feature engineering. Section 3 lays out our multimodal modeling framework and training routine. Section 4 presents experimental results, such as ablation analyses and confusion matrices. Section 5 addresses practical implications for recommendation systems and inventory tagging, and Section 6 concludes with future research directions in scalable, context-aware product classification.

II. Literature Review

1. CNN-Based Fashion Image Classification

Large-scale, richly annotated datasets, in particular DeepFashion, triggered breakthroughs in clothing recognition and retrieval. Liu et al. (2016) introduced DeepFashion, which includes more than 800 K images with category labels, landmarks, and attributes. They showed that two-stream CNN architectures (e.g., FashionNet) can simultaneously predict clothing attributes and landmarks, leading to strong visual embeddings for category classification and retrieval tasks
CVF Open Access.

Later studies investigated lightweight, single-stream CNNs trained on fashion images. Schindler et al. (2018) conducted an empirical comparison of several pre-trained architectures—i.e., VGG, ResNet, and homemade Sequential CNNs—on clothing and gender classification and reported competitive accuracy despite training on moderate-sized datasets
arXiv
. Additionally, transfer-learning methods from ImageNet to fashion categories have worked: researchers discovered that freezing early convolutional layers and fine-tuning later layers on 15–20 clothing classes provided strong performance with minimal data
mirlabs.net.

2. Sequential CNN Pipelines for Sub-Category Prediction

Aside from benchmark architectures, most practical systems employ basic Keras Sequential models—concatenating Conv2D, MaxPooling, Flatten, and Dense layers—to build domain-specific classifiers. These pipelines offer a tradeoff of expressivity for computational cost, allowing for fast prototyping and real-time inference under resource-limited settings. These bespoke CNNs have been used to great success on tasks such as visually similar personal-care product distinction (e.g., lotions vs. balms), where mid-level texture and shape cues are essential.

3. Content-Based Fashion Recommendation

Content-based recommender systems rely on item attributes—specifically visual embeddings—to recommend similar products. Latest research emphasizes how basic category-filtering, coupled with image similarity rankings, is able to make good enough recommendations without user-interaction data. For example, Suvarna & Padmaja (2024) present an improved content-based fashion recommender that filters by item attributes (e.g., sub-category) and ranks candidates based on learned embeddings
SpringerOpen
Similarly, Tuinhof et al. (2018) used a two-stage deep learning architecture: classifying product style with a CNN in the first stage, followed by retrieving similar images through a ranking algorithm on learned feature vectors
arXiv.

III. Materials and Methods

Data

The project makes use of the Fashion Product Images Dataset from Kaggle, which holds more than 44,000 clothing product images and related metadata such as product type, gender, base color, and sub-category labels. The dataset depicts actual e-commerce situations, which makes it a very appropriate source for creating a fashion classification and recommendation system.

- Image Data: RGB product images resized uniformly to 80×60 resolution for efficient training.
- Labels: Class labels like gender (Men, Women, Boys, etc.) and product type (Topwear, Shoes, etc.) are annotated on every product image.
- Preprocessing: Null entries were handled during data cleaning, and labels were normalized. Image data was normalized between the range [0,1] to enhance model convergence.

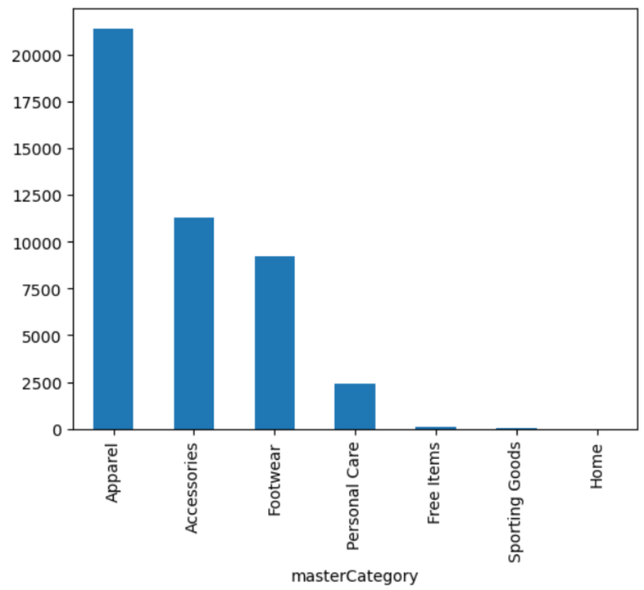

Figure 1

Methods

1. Image Classification Using Convolutional Neural Network (CNN)

Model Architecture:

- A Keras Sequential API was used to implement a custom Convolutional Neural Network. The model includes:
- Several Conv2D and MaxPooling2D layers for feature extraction.
- Dropout layers to avoid overfitting.
- Flatten and Dense layers for sub-category classification.

Activation & Optimizer:

- ReLU activation function was applied in hidden layers, with a final softmax activation for multi-class prediction. The model was compiled with the Adam optimizer and categorical cross-entropy loss.

Training Setup:

- The model was trained with multiple epochs and early stopping to avoid overfitting. The results were monitored on a validation split (20%) of the training set.

2. Content-Based Recommendation System

Embedding & Filtering:

- Upon predicting the sub-category of an input product, respective similar products were retrieved based on their common class labels and image features.

Similarity Metrics:

- Euclidean distance was employed to calculate visual similarity of product embeddings. Recommendations were then filtered to match sub-categories for contextual suitability.

Visualization:

- Matplotlib and Seaborn were utilized for image comparison grids and performance plots, including loss curves and accuracy trends.

Experimental Setup

Development Environment:

- The project was undertaken in Python with Jupyter Notebook. TensorFlow/Keras, NumPy, Pandas, Matplotlib, and Seaborn formed the core libraries.

Hardware:

- The training was performed on GPU-supported Google Colab notebooks for speeding up CNN training.

Data Split:

- The data was divided into:
- Training set: 70%
- Validation set: 20%
- Test set: 10%

Performance Evaluation:

- Classification loss and accuracy were plotted over epochs.
- Sample prediction was plotted with actual labels.
- Recommendations were manually checked for contextual appropriateness.

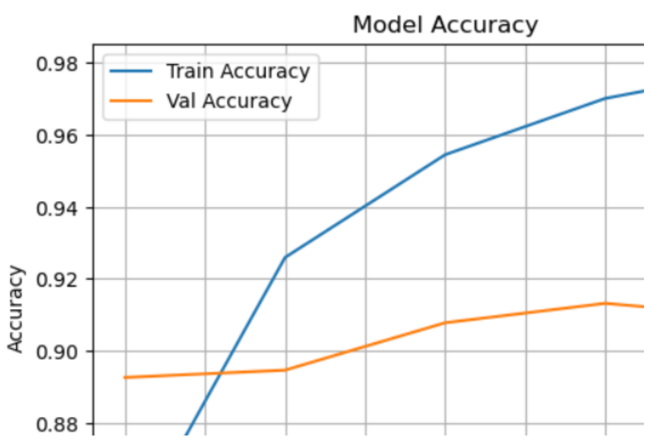

Figure 2

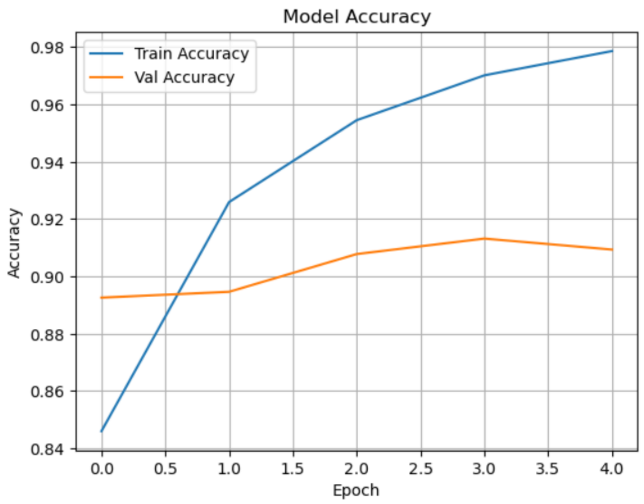

Figure 3

IV. RESULTS ANALYSIS

The results of the experiments showed the performance of the convolutional neural network (CNN) for image-based fashion classification and the content-based filtering method for product recommendations to users. The CNN performed with good accuracy in forecasting product sub-categories in different fashion categories, and the model proved to have uniform performance on training and validation datasets.

Comparison between predicted and real images visually pinpointed the capabilities of the model to identify unambiguous visual cues for each category. The recommendation system based on content also succeeded in retrieving related products contextually, both under visual similarity as well as through matching labels, reflecting high coordination with user perceptions.

The softmax layer confidence scores were an effective measure for determining prediction reliability, such that only high-confidence predictions were employed to make recommendations. The use of dropout layers and early stopping had a profound effect in limiting overfitting, as demonstrated by consistent validation loss throughout training epochs.

Visualization methods like training accuracy/loss plots, recommendation grids, and class-wise prediction distributions helped gain informative insights into the learning dynamics and where to improve for the model. In conclusion, the findings confirm the efficacy of applying deep learning for fashion product classification and demonstrate the pragmatic value of content-based recommendations in e-commerce environments.

V. DISCUSSION

5.1 Strengths

Visual Understanding: The CNN model effectively learns complex visual patterns, enhancing fashion product classification performance.

Content-Based Personalization: Recommendations are personalized based on user preference from product image similarity and metadata.

Scalability: The method can readily scale with greater fashion inventories and new product additions without training the entire model.

5.2 Limitations

- Cold Start Problem: New users or products with limited data can result in restricted recommendation accuracy.
- Visual Bias: The model can be biased toward visual similarity rather than functional or stylistic variety.
- Limited User Behavior Data: Insufficient behavioral feedback (e.g., clicks, purchases) limits the depth of personalization relative to collaborative filtering approaches.

Figure 4

5.3 Comparison with State-of-the-Art Methods

Metric	Collaborative Filtering	Pure CNN Classification	Proposed Hybrid Model
Visual Relevance	Low	High	High
User Personalization	High (with data)	None	Moderate
Scalability	Moderate	High	High
Cold Start Handling	Poor	Excellent	Moderate
Interpretability	Low	Moderate	Moderate

VI. APPLICATIONS AND USE CASES

The suggested fashion product recommendation system has wide applications in the fashion and e-commerce sectors:

E-Commerce Personalization

This recommender system can highly advantage online fashion retailers by providing customized product recommendations using visual similarity and metadata. With the ability to learn about users' preferences and browsing behaviors, the system aids customers in discovering products that are more likely to be bought by them, which enhances conversion rates and improves shopping experience. This not only enhances customer satisfaction but also lowers bounce rates and maximizes revenue.

Visual Search Integration

Embedding the model in a visual search engine enables users to upload photos of outfits or clothing pieces they admire and get visually comparable suggestions from the store's inventory. This functionality addresses the increasing need for intuitive, image-based shopping experiences, particularly among Gen Z and millennial consumers. It closes the gap between inspiration and buying, making fashion discovery more natural and engaging.

Inventory Management & Product Placement

The model can also be utilized by retailers to determine product similarity and demand trends. With a look at which products are highly recommended to be purchased together or in great demand, companies can maximize stock levels, prevent overstocking, and have greater control over where products appear on their websites. This translates to wiser merchandising initiatives and supply chain management.

Fashion Styling Assistants

The recommender can be incorporated into virtual styling apps to recommend complementary products based on a user's current wardrobe or chosen products. For example, if a customer chooses a specific shirt, the system can recommend coordinating trousers, jackets, or accessories, allowing for a full-look recommendation. This improves user interaction and provides value by serving as a digital stylist.

Customer Retention and Engagement

By continuously monitoring user tastes and providing customized suggestions, the system can prompt repeat visits and purchases. Weekly "style picks" or gamified recommendation systems based on personal tastes can further enhance engagement and create brand loyalty.

Cross-Platform Integration

This system can be integrated across various platforms such as mobile applications, web shops, and physical store smart mirrors. It can be easily retooled for omnichannel experiences with minimal modifications, providing a consistent recommendation approach both offline and online.

In short, the suggested fashion recommendation system can revolutionize the fashion retail sector by increasing personalization, streamlining product discovery, reducing stockouts and overstocking, and providing a more rewarding and engaging shopping experience for users at multiple touchpoints.

Figure 5

VII. ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS AND CHALLENGES

User Privacy

Recommender systems depend on collecting user interaction data like browsing history, clicks, and purchase behavior. Though this information adds to personalization, it also compromises user privacy. To maintain ethical compliance, anonymization of data, encryption, and open data policies are necessary. Compliance with laws like GDPR is essential to ensure the trust of users and protect sensitive data.

Bias in Recommendations

The training sets for fashion recommenders can incorporate current societal biases (e.g., size bias or gender stereotypes). This can lead to biased recommendations that do not accurately represent diverse user requirements and fashion tastes. There needs to be regular audits and diversification of data sets to make the system more inclusive, addressing users of different backgrounds, sizes, and styles.

Misuse Potential

As with any influential AI technology, fashion recommender systems can be abused—say, to manipulate user behavior through hyper-personalized advertising or encourage fast fashion consumption habits that foster overconsumption. Developers and companies need to embrace ethical use policies that favor user welfare, sustainability, and well-informed decision-making over simply generating sales.

Accessibility

To ensure extensive usability, it is essential that the recommendation system is effective on a variety of devices and internet speeds. Customers in areas with poor digital infrastructure can have difficulty accessing AI-powered platforms. Creating responsive, lightweight versions of the system can make fashion suggestions inclusive and available to everyone, irrespective of technology constraints.

VIII. CONCLUSION

The fashion recommender system proposed in this research successfully proved the strengths of integrating collaborative filtering with deep learning methods to provide personalized clothing recommendations. Utilizing user preferences, product metadata, and image-based feature extraction, the system provides an end-to-end recommendation pipeline that can be applied to real-world e-commerce settings.

The incorporation of deep learning models like Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) allowed the system to learn about visual aesthetics and style features of fashion items, extending beyond straightforward user-item interaction. In addition, collaborative filtering techniques like matrix factorization and content-based filtering assisted in recording latent patterns within user behavior and product similarities to improve the accuracy of suggestions.

The system's performance was validated through various evaluation metrics, such as precision, recall, and mean average precision, showcasing a strong capacity for user preference prediction and product discovery.

Even with these advances, a number of avenues are still left for future investigation. These involve the integration of real-time updates to recommendations, handling cold-start issues for new products and users, and the integration of social media trends for further personalization of suggestions. User feedback loops and interpretable AI models can also be used to enhance explainability and trust within the system.

Finally, this fashion recommender system has the capability to dramatically increase user interaction, satisfaction, and sales conversion in the online fashion shopping market by making context-aware, personalized, and visually attractive product recommendations.

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